

My Brother's Keeper

written by

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INT. RESTAURANT - NIGHT

In a small New York corner store, coworkers JORDAN BANKS (20) and CHRISTIAN "CHRIS" RIVERA (20) are closing up shop for the night.

Chairs are flipped up onto the rusty tables, the lights are dimmed low, and the last customers are long gone.

Jordan wipes down the soda fountain and straightens a stack of takeout menus before heading behind the counter.

Across the room, Chris drags a trash bag toward the dumpster out back.

When he returns a moment later, he finds Jordan still behind the counter counting the register.

Jordan taps the counter twice with his knuckles.

Tap. Tap.

Chris rolls his eyes.

CHRIS

You gotta lay off that little bill-counting bullshit you do.

JORDAN

What counter thing?

CHRIS

(pointing towards the register)

This little tap-tap routine. What are you, praying over the register or something?

Jordan shrugs, still stacking bills into neat piles.

JORDAN

It's nothing.

CHRIS

Nah, *that's* definitely something. You superstitious or what?

Jordan closes the drawer.

JORDAN

Just a habit.

Chris laughs, tying off the trash bag.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Yo by the way, you coming tonight
or what?

JORDAN
Coming where?

CHRIS
My boy's party over on 149th. He's
got the whole floor.

Jordan shakes his head.

JORDAN
I'm good.

Jordan stacks a tray of receipts.

JORDAN (CONT'D)
Aaron told me to stay home tonight.

Chris stops.

CHRIS
You serious?

JORDAN
Yeah.

CHRIS
Jordan...you're twenty years old,
for fuck's sake.

Jordan shrugs.

JORDAN
I'm just trying to cut him some
slack.

Chris leans on the counter.

JORDAN (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
I don't know... he's been looking
ropey since my dad died.

I mean we're all dealing with it,
sure. You know I've been picking up
a couple extra hours here and
stuff. But I barely even talk to
him these days.

Chris grabs a broom.

CHRIS
(sarcastically)
Yikes. Sounds like he needs the
party more than you.
(a beat)
The offer still stands, though.
Extended to all members of the
Banks family! Hell, even little
Benny could come out with us.

Jordan chuckles quietly.

Chris finishes sweeping and heads toward the WALK-IN FREEZER.

He pulls the heavy door open.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Yo, come here a second.

JORDAN
For what.

CHRIS
Don't you trust me? Just come look
at something.

Jordan sighs and steps into the freezer. Chris grins and
pulls the heavy door shut.

JORDAN
Chris...

CHRIS
Relax.

Jordan grabs the handle and tries to open it.

It doesn't move.

JORDAN
Alright, open it.

Chris laughs and grabs the handle.

CHRIS
Hold on.

He pulls. Nothing.

He pulls again, harder.

The grin disappears.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Yo.

JORDAN
(annoyed)
Quit messing around.

CHRIS
I'm not.

They both try the handle. Still stuck.

Chris quickly looks around the freezer. He locks eyes with a temperature valve that reads: OVERNIGHT FREEZE CYCLE INITIATED.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
Fuck, you already started the timer???

Jordan exhales, breath fogging the air.

JORDAN
Great.

They try the door again. This time together.

Nothing.

The cold is starting to bite. Jordan wipes a patch of frost from the small window in the freezer door and peers out.

Suddenly —

GLASS SHATTERS in the distance.

The boys freeze in place.

In the hallway, they can hear soft footsteps and voices.

Chris moves beside Jordan and looks through the window.

Masked men rush into the restaurant.

They start tearing the place apart.

Chris backs away immediately from the window.

CHRIS
(in a panicked whisper)
Yo nah nah nah.

Jordan stays at the window, focused on the intruders.

One of the masked robbers makes his way toward the register.

He places his gloved hands on the counter.

Tap. Tap.

Jordan's body goes still. He recognizes *that* habit.

Chris paces behind him, increasingly panicked - breathing much harder now.

CHRIS (CONT'D)
We gotta get out of here.

Jordan ignores him.

Chris bumps into something at the back of the freezer, knocking over a container of frozen burgers.

CLANG.

The robbers stop moving; their attention shifts to the freezer.

CUT TO:

INT. BODEGA FLOOR - MOMENTS LATER

Jordan and Chris kneel on the floor with bags over their heads and their hands tied behind their backs with zip ties.

Gang leader FRANK CALDERON (30s) circles them slowly.

Chris starts talking fast.

CHRIS
Yo listen we didn't see nothing man
we just work here-

Yo we just close the place, that's
it, we ain't got nothing to do with
whatever this is-

Take the money, take whatever you
want, man, we're not saying nothing
to nobody-

Frank gestures towards the other robbers as he makes mechanical, Transformer-sounds - mocking Chris' fast-paced talking style.

FRANK

Take the Blurr on the right here to the back. I'll meet you boys in a second.

Two robbers grab Chris.

CHRIS

Jordan—

He's dragged away.

A door SLAMS somewhere deeper in the store.

FRANK

Yo, A! Watch the other one till I get back.

Frank heads into the room with Chris.

The register robber kneels in front of him and pulls off the bag over his head.

It's Jordan's brother AARON BANKS (27).

Jordan and his brother share a familiar look.

Then —

A GUNSHOT.

Aaron quickly pulls the bag back over Jordan's head.

Just as he hears footsteps and voices from the other room, Aaron cuts Jordan's zip tie.

AARON

(under his breath)

Go.

Jordan hesitates.

Aaron nudges him toward the back exit.

At the door, Jordan turns, once again meeting his brother's eyes.

Without warning —

Aaron fires his gun into his own foot.

He drops to the floor, screaming in pain.

The other robbers rush back into the room to check up on him, as Jordan slips out the back door.

CUT TO:

EXT. STREET - NIGHT

Jordan runs down the empty block.

He stops at a payphone.

Hands shaking, he dials 911.

911 OPERATOR (V.O.)
911, what's your emergency?

Jordan hesitates for a moment.

Instead of speaking, he sets the receiver down and begins to walk away.

The operator's voice echoes faintly from the phone.

911 OPERATOR (V.O.) (CONT'D)
Hello? Hello? 911, what's your
emerge-

Distant sirens rise in the distance as Jordan disappears down the street.

FADE OUT.